

History—Indus Valley Civilization

Subject: History

The Indus Valley Civilization developed in parts of present-day Pakistan and northwestern India from roughly 2600 to 1900 BCE, during its mature urban phase. It is also called the Harappan Civilization, after Harappa, one of the first sites to be studied by modern archaeologists. Important cities included Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira, and Lothal. These settlements were connected by shared material culture, construction methods, artistic conventions, and systems of measurement. The civilization occupied a large and varied region that included river plains, semi-arid areas, and coastal zones, so its people adapted to different local environments rather than relying on a single landscape.

The cities show evidence of careful planning. Streets in several settlements followed fairly regular patterns, and houses were often built with standardized fired bricks. Many houses had courtyards, wells, bathing areas, and drains. Mohenjo-daro is especially famous for its covered drainage channels and the Great Bath, a large public structure that may have had ritual or social importance. Dholavira had reservoirs and water-management works suited to a drier environment. These features suggest that civic authorities, builders, and communities coordinated construction and maintenance. At the same time, archaeological evidence does not reveal a clearly identified palace, royal tomb, or large army monument, so the exact political system remains uncertain.

The economy combined farming, animal husbandry, craft production, fishing, and trade. Wheat, barley, pulses, sesame, and some fruits were cultivated in different areas. Cattle, water buffalo, sheep, goats, and other animals were kept, while fish and river resources supplemented food supplies. Craftspeople made pottery, beads, shell objects, metal tools, ornaments, and carved stone seals. Bead-making at sites such as Lothal required skilled drilling and polishing. Harappan weights appear to have followed consistent standards, which would have helped traders measure valuable materials. Seals decorated with animals and short inscriptions may have identified people, goods, institutions, or religious ideas, although the script has not yet been securely deciphered.

Trade connected the Indus region with neighboring areas. Archaeologists have found materials associated with Afghanistan, Iran, the Persian Gulf, and Mesopotamia. Carnelian beads, timber, metals, shells, and other goods could move through overland routes and coastal settlements. Mesopotamian records refer to a distant land called Meluhha, which many scholars associate with the Indus region, although the identification is not absolutely certain. Long-distance exchange required trust, transport knowledge, storage, and systems for recording or recognizing goods. The presence of similar objects across distant settlements also shows that ideas and techniques circulated alongside commodities.

Religion and social life are difficult to reconstruct because the writing system remains undeciphered. Small figurines, animal motifs, ritual-looking structures, burials, and the Great

Baths have encouraged many interpretations, but they should be treated cautiously. Archaeology can show patterns of behavior without providing the names of gods or the exact meanings of ceremonies. The civilization was not a simple collection of identical cities; local differences existed in architecture, crafts, diet, and burial practices. Evidence of organized sanitation and standardized production indicates cooperation, while differences in houses and goods may suggest social distinctions.

After about 1900 BCE, many large urban settlements declined or changed. The transformation was probably caused by several interacting factors rather than one sudden event. River courses may have shifted, monsoon patterns may have changed, and some regions may have faced ecological stress. Trade networks and centralized urban systems may also have weakened. People did not disappear; populations moved, cities became smaller, and cultural practices continued in new forms. The Indus Valley Civilization is therefore best understood as a long and diverse process of urban development, regional interaction, adaptation, and transformation. Its achievements in planning, water management, craft production, and standardized measurement remain important evidence of early complex society.